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Lead Technical Architect - AI

Department for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs

Apply before 11:55 pm on Monday 28th September 2026



Department
for Environment
Food & Rural Affairs

Reference number

467573

Salary

£56,375 - £69,105

Grade 7 National: £56,375 - £62,830 London: £62,000 - £69,105, plus industry leading pension and benefits.

For details of our pay on appointment policy, please see below under the heading Salary .

This post offers successful candidates the opportunity to be considered for an additional Digital, Data and Technology (DDaT) Skills Supplement. The level of the awarded supplement is determined following a separate skills assessment process, the outcome of which has no impact on the decision to make a job offer. This digital capability supplement ranges from £0 to £26,608 and you may be awarded a pay supplement within this range based on results of your additional skills assessment. For details of our pay on appointment policy, please see below under the heading [Salary](#) .

A [Civil Service Pension](#) with an employer contribution of 28.97%

Job grade

Grade 7

Contract type

Permanent

Business area

DEFRA - DGCS - Digital, Data, Technology & Security

Type of role

Architecture and Data

Digital

Information Technology

Working pattern

Flexible working, Full-time, Job share, Part-time

Number of jobs available

1

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Location

Bristol, London, York

About the job

Job summary

Defra is the UK government department responsible for safeguarding our natural environment, supporting our world-leading food and farming industry, and sustaining a thriving rural economy. Our broad remit means we play a major role in people's day-to-day life, from the food we eat, and the air we breathe, to the water we drink.

Digital, Data, Technology and Security (DDTS) is the trusted team for digital across the entire Defra Group.

We have around 1000 colleagues across DDTS and our ambition is to make it easier and faster than ever for people to interact with Defra. If you are ready to drive innovation and push boundaries, we want to hear from you. Join us and together we will create a great place for living, and a green and healthy future for all.

Find out more about DDTS:

[Defra digital, data and technology blog](#)

[LinkedIn](#)

[Defra Jobs](#)

[We are Government Digital and Data Candidate Information Pack V3 -](#)

Please note for this role you will require SC Clearance. To gain SC clearance all applicants are required to have been a UK resident for a minimum of 5 years. If this requirement is not met, the individual will not be able to progress their application further.

Job description

The AI Technical Architect is responsible for defining, assuring and maintaining Defra's technical architecture and approved design patterns for the use of artificial intelligence, including machine learning, generative and agentic AI systems. They will provide technical leadership and architectural oversight for AI-enabled systems, ensuring these are designed in line with HMG's Digital and Data standards and departmental architecture principles.

The role will ensure AI solutions adopted or developed across the department are technically robust, secure, operable and reusable, while avoiding unnecessary duplication or unmanaged risk. This will be achieved by defining clear technical guardrails, reference architectures and design patterns that teams can adopt with confidence.

The role will broadly:

- Define and maintain Defra's approved technical architecture and guardrails for AI

- Enable delivery teams to design AI systems that are secure, sustainable, ethical and interoperable

- Provide architectural assurance and expert technical advice for AI initiatives

- Reduce risk, duplication and technical debt associated with AI adoption

- Support responsible and proportionate innovation in the use of AI

Person specification

Responsibilities:

- Define, document and maintain AI technical reference architectures, standards and design patterns, covering areas such as cloud deployment, data access, security controls, model lifecycle management, evaluation, and monitoring.

Provide architectural advice and assurance to AI-related initiatives, including participation in design reviews, assurance clinics and architectural governance forums.

Work with Digital Delivery teams to support early-stage discovery and design of AI use cases, ensuring alignment with approved technical patterns.

Collaborate with wider CTO (Chief Technology Officer), Digital Delivery, Digital Transformation, GIO (Group Infrastructure Operations) and Chief Data Office areas to ensure AI architectures are aligned with enterprise architecture, infrastructure standards and operational requirements.

Embed responsible AI principles into technical designs by specifying appropriate technical controls such as logging, auditability, performance evaluation and human oversight.

Skills:

Ability to lead complex technical decision-making, balancing trade-offs between cost, risk, performance and sustainability.

Ability to translate organisational strategy into coherent technical architecture and long-term direction for AI systems.

Ensures architecture supports systems from discovery through to live operation, including deployment, monitoring and scaling.

Ability to embed security, identity, access control and compliance into architectural patterns.

Design architectures for data pipelines, model lifecycle management, evaluation and monitoring of AI systems.

Architectural assurance skills, including assessment of designs against standards, identification of risk and recommendation of mitigations.

Demonstrable skills/experience aligned to the Lead Technical Architect (G7) role (technical skills outlined below), within the Government Digital and Data Profession, specialising in AI and data-driven architectures:

Architect for the whole context: practitioner level

Architecture communication: expert level

Community collaboration: practitioner level

Making architectural decisions: practitioner level

Strategy design: practitioner level

Technical design throughout the life cycle: expert level

For further information on these technical skills please refer to the [framework](#).

Experience:

Technical architecture design experience for complex, cloud-based digital systems (primarily Azure and AWS), including distributed and data-intensive architectures.

Secure-by-design architecture design experience, including identity and access management, encryption, logging, auditability and resilience.

Deep understanding of AI/ML system components and lifecycle, including data pipelines, model development, MCP (Model Context Protocol), agentic workflows, model orchestration, deployment, evaluation, continuous monitoring and retirement.

Experience working with cloud-native and data-intensive systems and systems with high availability, security or regulatory requirements.

Selection process

The Civil Service marks each element of the selection process on a merit basis. You can visit the [gov.uk website](https://www.gov.uk) for further information on the Civil Service rating scale.

Ensure you have tailored your CV and Personal Statement to the 'skills and experience' section of the job advert by providing examples on how you are suitable for the role using the [STAR method](#).

Please ensure you demonstrate clearly, within your personal statement, how you meet these requirements, as the information you provide will form a key part when the panel is scoring your application.

For further information on STAR, you can check out our [Hints and Tips](#) document.

Application process

As part of the application process, you will be assessed on your experience. This will be evaluated by looking at your CV and personal statement, so please provide the following and ensure your experience is clearly demonstrated:

A CV

A 750 word Personal Statement: Referring to the 'skills and experience' sections of the job advert, please demonstrate how you are suitable for the role by providing relevant examples.

Further details around what this will entail are listed on the application form.

Sift

Sift will begin shortly after the advert closes.

Should there be a large number of applications, an initial sift will be conducted using your personal statement. Candidates who pass the initial sift may be progressed to a full sift, or progressed straight to assessment or interview.

Interview

If successful at sift, you will be invited to an interview where you will be assessed on the Behaviours and Technical Skills listed below, as well as Experience and Strengths.

As part of the recruitment process you may be required to do a presentation, confirmation of a presentation and the question to answer will be provided following the sift, for all candidates invited to interview.

Sift and Interview dates are to be confirmed. Please note that these may be subject to change.

Interviews will be held virtually on Microsoft Teams.

For further information on [Success Profiles](#), you can visit the links below and [watch our videos on DefraJobs](#).

Behaviours

We'll assess you against these behaviours during the selection process:

Making Effective Decisions

Communicating and Influencing

Delivering at Pace

Technical skills

We'll assess you against these technical skills during the selection process:

Architect for the whole context: practitioner level

Architecture communication: expert level

Community collaboration: practitioner level

Making architectural decisions: practitioner level

Strategy design: practitioner level

Technical design throughout the life cycle: expert level

Benefits

Alongside your salary of £56,375, Department for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs contributes £16,331 towards you being a member of the Civil Service Defined Benefit Pension scheme. [Find out what benefits a Civil Service Pension provides \(opens in a new window\)](#).

25 days leave (rising to 30 days over 5 years) plus bank holidays.

A [Civil Service pension](#) with an average employer contribution of 28.97%.

A day off per year for the King's birthday.

Access to a range of retail discounts (these include supermarket, tech, gym, holiday, phone and more).

Flexible working options such as condensed hours, part-time and flexi time.

3 paid volunteering days per year.

Funding for professional membership of a recognised professional body.

Learning and development tailored to your role and budget for training or qualifications.

A culture encouraging inclusion and diversity.

Cycle to work scheme.

Health cash plan to help you manage health costs for a reduced monthly fee.

Access to the Employee Assistance Programme open 24 hours, 7 days a week, that provides support to you during any times of stress or difficulty.

Free access to Headspace for wellbeing.

Season ticket loan for public transport.

Things you need to know

Artificial intelligence

Artificial intelligence can be a useful tool to support your application, however, all examples and statements provided must be truthful, factually accurate and taken directly from your own experience. Where plagiarism has been identified (presenting the ideas and experiences of others, or generated by artificial intelligence, as your own) applications may be withdrawn and internal candidates may be subject to disciplinary action. Please see our [candidate guidance \(opens in a new window\)](#) for more information on appropriate and inappropriate use.

Selection process details

This vacancy is using [Success Profiles \(opens in a new window\)](#), and will assess your Behaviours, Strengths, Experience and Technical skills.

For further information on the selection process for this role, please refer to the person specification section of the job advert.

Location

As part of the pre-employment process for this post, successful candidate(s) will be able to agree a contractual workplace from those locations listed in this advert. The agreed contractual workplace is then the substantive and permanent place of work for the successful candidate(s).

Where the location is National the successful appointee should discuss and agree an appropriate contractual location in line with both Defra's location policy and site capacity, prior to proceeding with pre-employment processes.

The agreed amount of time spent at a workplace for this post will reflect the requirement for Civil Servants to spend at least 60% of their working time in an organisation workplace with the option to work the remaining time flexibly from home. Working time spent at a workplace may include time spent at other organisational locations including field-based operational locations, together with supplier, customer or partner locations. This is a non-contractual agreement which is consistent with common Civil Service expectations.

Travel costs to non-contractual workplaces will be subject to departmental travel and subsistence policies. Travel costs to contractual workplaces are the responsibility of the employee.

The successful candidate is required to carry out all their duties from a UK location, and cannot do so from an overseas location at any time.

Defra includes the core department, APHA, RPA, Cefas and VMD.

Reserve list

A reserve list may be held for a period of 12 months from which further appointments can be made.

Near miss

Candidates who are judged to be a near miss at interview may be considered for other positions in Defra which may be at a lower grade, but have a potential skills match.

Merit Lists

Where more than one location is advertised, candidates will be posted in merit order by location. You will be asked to state your location preference on your application.

Salary

New entrants to the Civil Service are expected to start on the minimum of the pay band. The internal roles rules apply to existing Civil Servants, i.e. level transfers move on current salary or the pay range minimum, transfers on promotion move to new pay range minimum or receive 10% increase. Either case is determined by whichever is the highest.

Childcare Vouchers

Any move to Defra from another employer will mean you can no longer access childcare vouchers. This includes moves between government departments. You may however be eligible for other government schemes, including Tax Free Childcare; for further information [visit the Childcare Choices website](#).

Reasonable adjustment

If a person with disabilities is put at a substantial disadvantage compared to a non-disabled person, we have a duty to make reasonable changes to our processes.

If you need a change to be made so that you can make your application, you should:

Contact Government Recruitment Service via defrarecruitment.grs@cabinetoffice.gov.uk as soon as possible before the closing date to discuss your needs.

Complete the Assistance required section in the Additional requirements page of your application form to tell us what changes or help you might need

further on in the recruitment process. For instance, you may need wheelchair access at interview, or if you're deaf, a Language Service Professional.

Accessibility

If you are experiencing accessibility problems with any attachments on this advert, please contact the email address in the 'contact point for applicants' section.

Visa Sponsorship Statement

Please take note that Defra does not hold a UK Visa & Immigration (UKVI) Skilled Worker License sponsor and are unable to sponsor any individuals for Skilled Worker Sponsorship.

Criminal Record Check

If successful and transferring from another Government Department a criminal record check may be carried out.

In order to process applications without delay, we will be sending a Criminal Record Check to Disclosure and Barring Service on your behalf.

However, we recognise in exceptional circumstances some candidates will want to send their completed forms direct. If you will be doing this, please advise Government Recruitment Service of your intention by emailing Pre-EmploymentChecks.grs@cabinetoffice.gov.uk stating the job reference number in the subject heading.

Internal Fraud Database Check

Applicants who are successful at interview will be, as part of pre-employment screening, subject to a check on the Internal Fraud Database (IFD). This check will provide information about employees who have been dismissed for fraud or dishonesty offences. This check also applies to employees who resign or otherwise leave before being dismissed for fraud or dishonesty had their employment continued. Any applicant's details held on the IFD will be refused employment.

A candidate is not eligible to apply for a role within the Civil Service if the application is made within a 5 year period following a dismissal for carrying out internal fraud against government.

Higher Security Clearance

For further information on National Security Vetting please [visit the Demystifying Vetting website](#).

Feedback

Feedback will only be provided if you attend an interview or assessment.

Security

Successful candidates must undergo a basic (or equivalent) criminal record check.

Successful candidates must meet the security requirements before they can be appointed. The level of security needed is [security check \(opens in a new window\)](#).

[See our vetting charter \(opens in a new window\)](#).

People working with government assets must complete [baseline personnel security standard \(opens in new window\)](#) checks.

Nationality requirements

This job is broadly open to the following groups:

UK nationals

nationals of the Republic of Ireland

nationals of Commonwealth countries who have the right to work in the UK

nationals of the EU, Switzerland, Norway, Iceland or Liechtenstein and family members of those nationalities with settled or pre-settled status under the [European Union Settlement Scheme \(EUSS\) \(opens in a new window\)](#)

nationals of the EU, Switzerland, Norway, Iceland or Liechtenstein and family members of those nationalities who have made a valid application for settled or pre-settled status under the European Union Settlement Scheme (EUSS)

individuals with limited leave to remain or indefinite leave to remain who were eligible to apply for EUSS on or before 31 December 2020

Turkish nationals, and certain family members of Turkish nationals, who have accrued the right to work in the Civil Service

[Further information on nationality requirements \(opens in a new window\)](#)

Working for the Civil Service

The [Civil Service Code \(opens in a new window\)](#) sets out the standards of behaviour expected of civil servants.

We recruit by merit on the basis of fair and open competition, as outlined in the Civil Service Commission's [recruitment principles \(opens in a new window\)](#).

The Civil Service embraces diversity and promotes equal opportunities. As such, we run a Disability Confident Scheme (DCS) for candidates with disabilities who meet the minimum selection criteria.

The Civil Service also offers a Redeployment Interview Scheme to civil servants who are at risk of redundancy, and who meet the minimum requirements for the advertised vacancy.

Diversity and Inclusion

The Civil Service is committed to attract, retain and invest in talent wherever it is found. To learn more please see the [Civil Service People Plan \(opens in a new window\)](#) and the [Civil Service Diversity and Inclusion Strategy \(opens in a new window\)](#).

Apply and further information

This vacancy is part of the [Great Place to Work for Veterans \(opens in a new window\)](#) initiative.

The Civil Service welcomes applications from people who have recently left prison or have an unspent conviction. [Read more about prison leaver recruitment \(opens in new window\)](#).

Once this job has closed, the job advert will no longer be available. You may want to save a copy for your records.

Contact point for applicants

Job contact :

Name : DDTSonPayrollRecruitment@defra.gov.uk

Email : DDTSonPayrollRecruitment@defra.gov.uk

Recruitment team

Email : defrarecruitment.grs@cabinetoffice.gov.uk

Further information

If you feel your application has not been treated in accordance with the Recruitment Principles and you wish to make a complaint, in the first instance, you should contact Government Recruitment Services via email: defrarecruitment.grs@cabinetoffice.gov.uk

If you are not satisfied with the response you receive from the Department, you can contact the Civil Service Commission: [here](#)

